

Interior Landscapes

The challenge of representing consciousness in fiction has long preoccupied modernist writers. Virginia Woolf, in her essay *Characters in Fiction*, critiques Edwardian authors for focusing too much on material detail, remarking that they have “given [readers] a house in the hope that [readers] may be able to deduce the human beings who live there (10).” She continues, “if you hold that novels are in the first place about people, and only in the second about the houses they live in, that is the wrong way to set about it (10).” For Woolf, this reliance on the external risks neglecting the rich interiority that defines human experience. She urges writers to construct their narratives from within, prioritizing the mind’s depth and complexity over surface realism. Elizabeth Bowen’s *The House in Paris* answers this challenge by transforming the architectural space of the house into a dynamic metaphor for the intricacies of consciousness. Where traditional narrative approaches often relied on external descriptions and linear plot progression, Bowen employs architectural metaphors to spatialise the rich, fragmented inner worlds of her characters. In doing so, she aligns with Woolf’s modernist imperative, using spatial symbolism to externalize the fluid, non-linear processes of thought and self-awareness. The titular house itself becomes an active participant in the narrative, encoding complex emotional histories and revealing the characters’ struggles against social expectations and internal conflicts.

Bowen’s approach reimagines Woolf’s critique as a creative tool. While Woolf dismisses preoccupations with material details like houses, Bowen transforms the house into an active force that reveals her characters’ inner lives and complexities. The house is not used as an end in itself, but as an integral force in revealing the inner lives and complexities of her characters. In fact, Bowen treats houses like an extension of her characters’ inner selves. In doing so, she gives

herself a loophole in Woolf's critique. In her description of Mme Fisher's bedroom, we as the reader can begin to see and understand the stuffy and claustrophobic presence of Mme Fisher, even for young Henrietta. As she walks into the room, Henrietta is introduced to "jalousies [...] pulled to over the far window, so that no light fell across the head of the bed (36)," and "a cone of sick-room incense on the bureau [that] sent spirals up the daylight near the door; daylight fell cold white on the honeycomb quilt rolled back (36)." The lack of light on the bed hints at Mme Fisher's controlling and secretive nature, which is more clearly revealed later, creating a space that feels oppressive and curated to maintain her authority.

The physical details of the room—such as the drawn jalousies and the incense—serve not only to define the atmosphere but also to symbolize Madame Fisher's later revealed manipulation of those around her, casting shadows both literally and metaphorically. Bowen notes that "Henrietta had never been in a room so full and still (36)." Through the eyes of Henrietta, we can see that the house—and particularly its specific rooms—functions as a complex psychological cartography, revealing the intricate interior landscapes of characters through carefully orchestrated psycho-spatial parallels. By transforming architectural spaces into dynamic extensions of consciousness, Bowen materializes Woolf's modernist commitment to exploring psychological depth, using the physical environment itself as a nuanced narrative mechanism for character revelation.

In *Consciousness and The Novel*, Lodge asserts that "we not only have experiences, we are conscious of ourselves having them, and of being affected by them (14)." As different characters in *The House of Paris* struggle through different situations, the house seems to shift in parallel to their internal states. These shifting appearances of the house are not merely physical

descriptions but serve as mirrors of the characters' consciousness. By using the environment as qualia, Bowen transforms the house into a way to convey characters' subjective experiences indirectly, through sensory and atmospheric details. This subjectivity is evidence of Bowen's commitment to the construction and representation of consciousness in the novel. As Lodge argues, "all these stories, and the selves they construct, are illusions, epiphenomena: to suppose otherwise would be to commit the fallacy of dualism (15)." Bowen's nuanced portrayal of the house exemplifies this perspective, illustrating how subjective perception shapes the world of the novel.

The house in Paris, while largely negative for all characters, serves different purposes depending on the character's relationship to it, and thus shifts accordingly. For Naomi, it is an immovable anchor, tying her not only to her mother but also to the burdens of familial obligation. Even after her engagement to Max, she tells Karen that she "could not leave [her mother] (100)," implicitly tying her inability to leave the house to her deep-seated emotional entanglements. Similarly, a decade later, Madame Fisher, now ill and confined to her bedroom, becomes a literal prisoner of the space, her existence maintained by Miss Fisher's obsessive caretaking and insistence on prolonged sleep. For both Naomi and Madame Fisher, the house is not merely a physical structure but an extension of their constrained inner lives, symbolizing how family ties and obligations can suffocate and immobilize.

In contrast, for Henrietta and Leopold, as well as the other "well-bred, well-fed, well-read English-speaking girls (100)" who have visited in the past, the house functions as a temporary vessel, something to pass through rather than be tied to. Yet even this transient relationship to the space carries its own limitations. Miss Fisher's insistence on caring for her mother and Karen's last-minute cancellation trap the children within the house, isolating them from the wider city

and forcing them to confront their respective identities and dilemmas. The house thus acts as both a literal boundary and a psychological one, reflecting the children's sense of displacement and their lack of agency. Through this dynamic relationship between characters and the house, Bowen uses architecture to externalize the interior lives of her characters.

Bowen mirrors Woolf's modernist approach by depicting the house as a dynamic site where past and present converge in the characters' minds. The fragmented narrative structure allows memory and perception to flow freely, collapsing temporal boundaries within the house. For instance, Leopold's experience in the house becomes a negotiation between his present disorientation and the echoes of his mother's past, as the physical space seems imbued with the weight of history. Shortly after he is told that his mother cannot come, "Leopold turned round facing the mantelpiece and suddenly ground his forehead against the marble. (204)" This violent act of dismay reminds the readers of Max's movements ten years ago when he came to confront Naomi about his affair, standing "with his back to the mantelpiece; after that [Naomi] saw that [her] presence martyred him (189)." This spatial and temporal mirroring reveals the house as a palimpsest of emotional experiences, where individual moments of psychological intensity are layered and inscribed upon one another. The mantelpiece becomes a symbolic and literal locus of familial trauma, with Leopold's gesture of anguish echoing and reframing Max's earlier moment of emotional confrontation. Here, the motif of the mantelpiece exemplifies how the house affords a unique blend of the abstract and the concrete; it serves as a tangible focal point of action and emotion, while also symbolising the enduring weight of family history and psychological inheritance. Leopold's physical response becomes a visceral manifestation of inherited

psychological landscapes, where personal pain is not simply experienced but spatially and generationally transmitted.

When Ray comes in Karen's stead to see Leopold, Ray uses the alabaster box as an ashtray. This alabaster box had once been promised by Mme Fisher to Karen when she first got engaged to Ray. However, "when Ray ground out his cigarette in the white lid, the lid skidded off the table to smash on the waxed floor (222)." The alabaster box is originally a symbol of the hope that once defined Karen and Ray's relationship, while its breaking a decade later highlights the fragility of those hopes and the impossibility of reclaiming what was lost. For Ray, this act also represents an unconscious release of the emotional burden he carries, acknowledging that their relationship can never be repaired as he meets Leopold, proof of Karen's infidelity. The recurring symbolic gestures, with the mantelpiece and the alabaster box, suggest a hereditary pattern of emotional suppression and unresolved familial tensions. By collapsing temporal boundaries and creating these subtle, almost imperceptible connections, Bowen explores the complex ways in which individual consciousness is fundamentally shaped by familial and spatial memory.

As an outsider to the familial history, Henrietta approaches the Fishers' house with a more detached perspective, her consciousness less burdened by emotional entanglements. Her perceptions mirror Woolf's exploration of consciousness in *The Mark on the Wall*, demonstrating how sensory experiences generate a fluid, associative mode of thinking. Initially struck by the house's apparent narrowness, Henrietta's perception shifts as she moves through the space as "she thought: Perhaps it is not really so small inside? Or perhaps it stretches back... (9)" Her observations become a dynamic process of spatial negotiation, with her consciousness actively

reinterpreting the architectural environment. She begins to antagonise the house, as she “felt the house was acting, nothing seemed to be natural; objects did not wait to be seen but came crowding in on her, each with what amounted to its aggressive cry (10).” This confrontation with the environment echoes Woolf’s depiction of the mark on the wall, where the narrator’s consciousness is similarly shaped by external details, jumping from the small mark to the thought of “the rapidity of life, the perpetual waste and repair; all so casual, all so haphazard (4).” Both Bowen and Woolf illustrate how objects and spaces become focal points for expansive, introspective explorations of perception.

When Henrietta enters Miss Fisher’s bedroom, she finds that “here a window opened on steep roofs; raw town air came in. The cabinet with its unexpected fittings enchanted Henrietta, who thereupon decided that Miss Fisher’s humility could have nothing to do with money (10).” This duality of Henrietta’s quick judgments exemplifies how consciousness operates not as a linear progression, but rather as a complex network of impressions that continually reshape her perception of her environment. The shifts in her consciousness resonate with Woolf’s insight about the mercurial nature of consciousness, echoing the idea that thoughts “swarm upon a new object, lifting it a little way, as ants carry a blade of straw so feverishly, and then leave it (3).” Bowen captures this psychological fluidity by externalizing internal worlds, as shown by the house’s impressions on Henrietta. When Henrietta observes the unexpected fittings of Miss Fisher’s cabinet, her immediate enchantment contrasts with the rawness of the air and steep roofs outside the window, embodying the house’s duality as both enchanting and unrefined. This interplay between internal perception and external detail reinforces how Bowen uses the house to mediate and reflect the fluidity of consciousness itself. In doing so, she redefines narrative space

as not just a backdrop but a participant in the unfolding of consciousness, aligning with Woolf's vision of the novel as a form that prioritizes subjective reality over objective coherence.

With the continual interaction between the past and present, the house in Paris becomes a site of psychological encounter and revelation. The relationship between the two storylines allows the reader to be aware of the characters as they are “conscious of existing in time, moving from a past [they] can recall very patchily, and into a future that is unknown and unknowable (31),” as Lodge states about the narrative nature of human consciousness. Lodge's comment underscores the fragmented and selective nature of memory, which shapes not only how the characters perceive themselves but also how they navigate their relationships and surroundings. For Mme Fisher, the patchy past and her illness is a tool at her disposal, which she uses to manipulate different characters in her dark room, especially Leopold.

During their conversation, Mme Fisher chooses to tell Leopold that his father was unaware of Leopold's existence, “deliberately [shutting] her eyes, which till the moment had been burning at Leopold like an old lion's out of their caves of bone (210).” This encounter between Leopold and Mme Fisher represents a pivotal moment of psychological encounter, where identity is negotiated through the fragmented landscape of memory and revelation. Bowen constructs this interaction as a complex performative space, where information becomes a strategic currency of power and vulnerability. Mme Fisher's deliberate obscurity—embodied in her metaphorical “caves of bone” and her strategic shutting of eyes—transforms the exchange into a calculated psychological manipulation. The physicality of Mme Fisher's dark room becomes a profound metaphor for the opacity of individual consciousness. By controlling the narrative of Leopold's origins, she enacts the modernist understanding of identity as

fundamentally unstable and narratively constructed. Her selective disclosure creates a moment of profound psychological destabilization for Leopold, whose sense of self is contingent upon these fragmentary revelations. The performative nature of Mme Fisher's revelation suggests that identity is not simply discovered, but actively performed and negotiated. Her eyes, which burned "like an old lion's out of their caves of bone (210)," suggest a predatory intellectual engagement, where knowledge is a form of power and vulnerability.

Lodge's statements on consciousness as a "narrative full of lacunae (31)" underlines the fragmented and selective nature of memory and perception, emphasizing how human understanding is constructed through incomplete and often unreliable stories. This metafictional approach underscores the artifice of narrative construction, highlighting how gaps and inconsistencies in memory shape not only personal identity but also the very act of storytelling. Bowen's narration echoes this perspective by intertwining the artifice of narrative with the psychological depth of her characters. Bowen's narrative exposes these lacunae through both the structure of the novel and the unreliable perspectives of her characters. The spatial dynamics of Mme Fisher's room, confined and oppressive, serve as a microcosm of these narrative gaps. Within this narrow, dark space, Leopold's psychological confinement mirrors the broader theme of fragmented identity and disjointed memory. The room becomes a liminal space where past and present collide, revealing the characters' struggles to reconcile their histories with their current realities. Yet, Bowen's metafictional narrative does more than explore individual psychology; it actively engages with and draws attention to its own processes. By embedding layers of memory and perception into the house itself, Bowen aligns with Lodge's assertion that consciousness is an intricate interplay of what is remembered, imagined, and omitted.

Through the shifting experiences of characters like Leopold, Henrietta, and Mme Fisher, Bowen demonstrates how architectural spaces can externalize the complexities of human consciousness, offering readers a lens into the psychological depths that shape the characters' lives. Ultimately, *The House in Paris* exemplifies the modernist novel's ability to break free from traditional constraints, capturing the elusive nature of consciousness through the interplay of spatial and psychological dimensions. Bowen's narrations highlight the intimate connections between place and self, illustrating how the physical world can serve as a profound conduit for exploring the fluid and multifaceted nature of human experience. In doing so, she fulfills and expands upon the modernist imperative to reimagine the boundaries of literary representation.